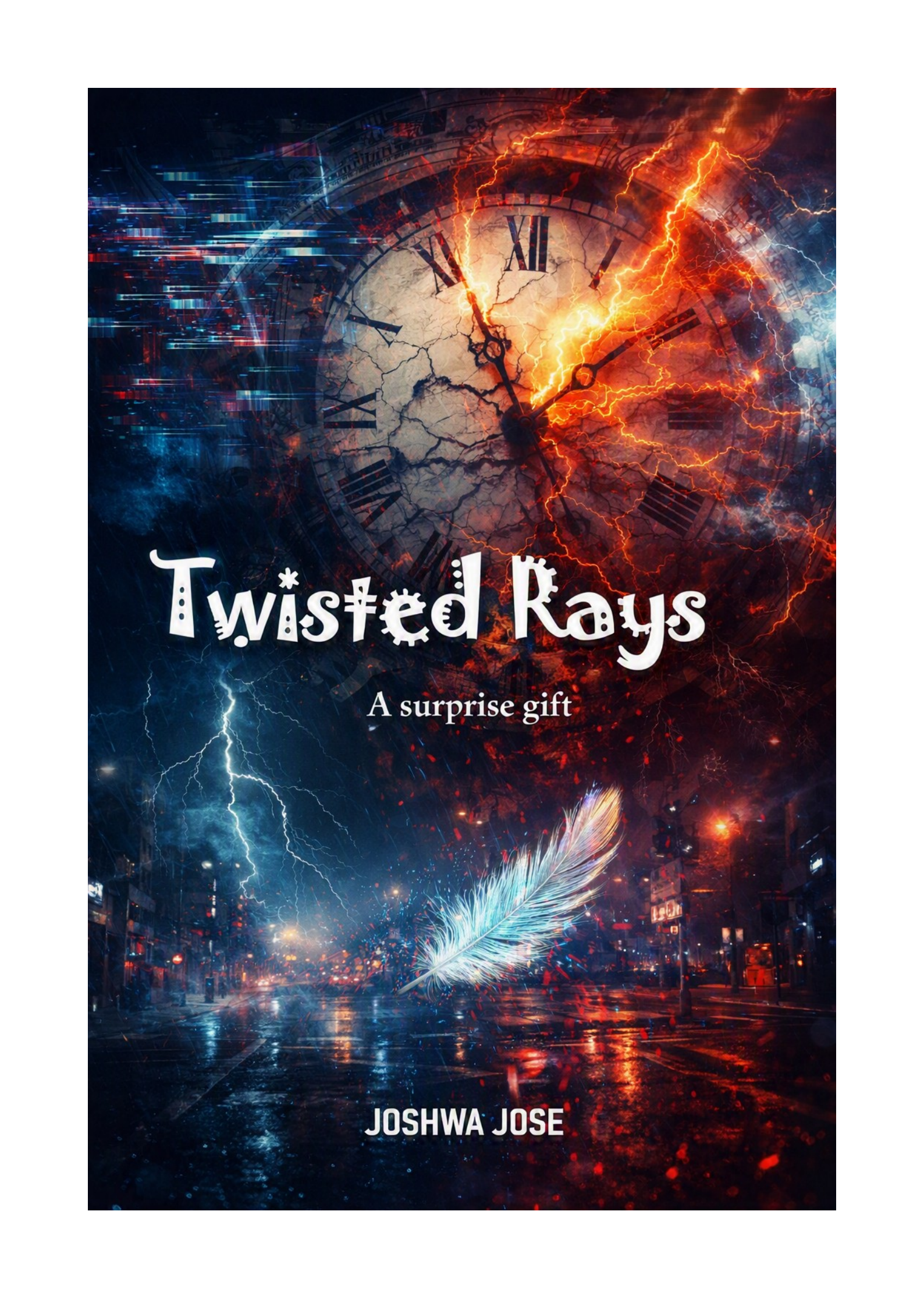




Twisted Rays

A surprise gift

JOSHUA JOSE

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First Edition, 2026

Published by

Thursday Narrations

An imprint of Thursday

Website: <https://thursdayarts.github.io/thursday/>

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Printed in India

For permissions, inquiries, and updates, please visit the publisher website

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Chapter One: The Long Rain

The town of Woodenberry hummed with holiday traffic and overlapping voices. It was Christmas Eve, and the air held the heavy, charged weight of an impending downpour. When the first heavy drops finally struck the asphalt, they landed squarely on the face of Alex Donovan, who lay unconscious near the hospital entrance.

He woke with a sharp intake of breath, blinking against the chill. A profound sense of disorientation settled over him; nothing looked or felt right. He felt completely isolated, stripped of bearings he thought he knew by heart. A gnawing hunger eventually drove him toward a cluster of nearby shops.

Stepping into a brightly lit diner, he approached the counter.

"Sir, can I have a chicken schmoise?" Alex asked.

The hotel staff exchanged blank looks. "Sorry, sir. We don't carry that item, and honestly, I've never even heard of it."

Frowning, Alex glanced at the menu board. "Then what do you have instead?"

"We have noodles and chili beef," the waiter replied.

Alex placed his order and sat down to wait. As he sat, he noticed the patrons around him; everyone wore heavy winter jackets. For the first time in what felt like a lifetime, his eyes caught the sweep of a wall clock. He flagged down a passing waiter. "Hey, what's that?"

The waiter paused, looking confused and slightly amused. "Sir? You mean the clock?"

"Yeah... yeah, that clock. I haven't seen one of those in years."

The waiter walked away, shooting him an uneasy glance. When the food arrived, Alex ate quickly. Finished, he swiped his fingers across the tabletop, expecting the electronic transaction to clear. Nothing happened.

He raised a hand. "Excuse me, where is the swipe pay terminal? At home, it's usually built right into the table."

Suspicion rippled through the staff. They began to murmur, wondering if the man was playing a cruel prank or simply trying to dine and dash. The waiter brought over the manager, who maintained a polite, careful smile.

"Evening, sir. Let's clear this up," the manager said calmly. "We don't know anything about swipe pay or systems like that. Is this a joke, or do you genuinely not have the money to pay?"

Alex stared at him, bewildered. He firmly rejected the accusations, his voice rising in frustration. Refusing to entertain the disruption further, the manager called the police.

"Who are you calling?" Alex demanded.

"The cops," the manager replied flatly.

Alex stood up, his posture rigid. He tried to project confidence, but an underlying dread told him something was fundamentally wrong here.

Minutes later, a patrol officer walked into the diner. "Who's the manager?"

"I am, sir. Name's Davy O'Malley," the manager said, stepping forward. "That's the customer who refused to pay his bill."

The staff pointed toward Alex. As Alex stepped up to explain his situation, the officer cut him off with hostile remarks, threatening him with arrest and insulting him over the unpaid meal. Reality finally sank in: the biometric payment technology he relied on didn't exist here.

Realizing the mounting tension was driving away other customers, O'Malley intervened. "Look, let's just write this off, Officer. It's Christmas Eve; nobody wants a fuss. Let's just get him out of here and clear the room."

Between the manager's dismissal and the officer's rough handling, Alex was pushed out onto the cold street. He stood in the rain, unable to process the sequence of events.

He began to wander aimlessly. The streets of Woodenberry looked hauntingly familiar, yet entirely wrong. The layout, the building placements, and the alignment of the blocks were subtly altered. Advertising boards and posters featured unfamiliar faces none of the modern celebrity projections or holographic displays he knew.

Spotting a police cruiser parked near a corner, he rushed over, chest heaving as he fought to catch his breath.

"Sir... please, I need help," Alex stammered. "Something is wrong. My phone, my wallet... everything is missing. Even the microchip in my hand is gone."

The officer behind the wheel rolled down the window. "Hey, calm down. Whoa, slow down. What happened?"

Alex repeated his frantic concerns, struggling to keep his voice steady. The officers exchanged skeptical glances, asking standard verification questions before offering a dismissive promise to look into it.

Desperate, Alex asked to use the cruiser's communication terminal to call his wife. He rattled off a ten digit sequence. The automated voice chimed back instantly: *The number does not exist.*

Shock rooted him to the spot. He tried dialing again, his fingers trembling.

"All right, give me the phone back," the officer said, losing patience.

Before Alex could process the command, the officer snatched the handheld unit from his grip. The cruiser pulled away from the curb, leaving Alex standing alone on the slick asphalt beneath the steady downpour.

Panic took over. He broke into a run, his lungs burning, driven by a primal urge to reach safety. He turned down his familiar neighborhood street, only to find the architectural alignment completely foreign.

With a brittle, manufactured confidence, he marched up to the front porch of what should have been his home and knocked twice.

A woman's voice called from inside. "Coming..."

The door swung open. A stranger stood in the entryway, looking startled. "Who are you?"

"I... I should ask you that," Alex said, breathless. "I'm Alex. Who are you?"

"I'm Mary Richards. Who are *you*?" she countered, her expression hardening.

"Sorry, ma'am, I might be turned around, but this is my house," Alex insisted, stepping closer. "How long have you lived here?"

She crossed her arms, clearly offended. "I've lived in this house for over twenty years. Now, respectfully, get off my property."

"No, that's impossible," Alex argued, his voice cracking. "This is my house. Where is my wife, Sarah Donovan? We moved in together five years ago!"

As their argument escalated, Mary reached for her phone. Recognizing the danger of police involvement, Alex pleaded with her to stop, but it was too late. She slammed the door in his face.

Left alone on the porch, Alex sank onto the cold steps, his mind racing as he tried to figure out how to survive a world that had erased him.

Chapter Two: The Red Shift

The patrol cruiser slowed to a crawl before idling by the curb. Two officers stepped out, their boots crunching against the wet pavement as they approached the porch.

"Are you the intruder?" one of them barked, locking eyes with Alex.

Frustration flared through his chest. "Sir, this is my home," Alex insisted, standing his ground. "I was expecting my wife here, but instead, this lady claims this is her house, which is completely untrue."

"Shut your mouth and keep it zipped," the older officer snapped, turning to his partner. "Cuff the rookie, put the bracelets on him."

While the younger officer shoved the cuffs onto Alex's wrists, the first officer rang the doorbell. Mary Richards opened the door a crack, her expression guarded. After a brief exchange, during which she reiterated that she had owned the property for decades, the officers formally detained him.

Forced into the back of the cruiser, Alex yelled against the glass partition, only to be met with cold demands for silence. At the station, he was marched into an interrogation room, his cuffed hands anchored to a bolt on the metal table.

Moments later, the door creaked open. A weary-looking detective stepped in, dropped a freshly printed incident report on the desk, and pulled out a chair.

"Hello, Alex," the detective said, leaning forward. "My name is Arthur Smith."

Alex immediately launched into an urgent plea of innocence, retracing his steps from the moment he woke up in the rain. Detective Smith listened, his pen tapping a rhythmic, impatient beat against the laminate table.

"What do you do for a living, Alex? Name a single contact," Smith interrupted, his voice sharpening. "You claim your wife and her number don't exist. Is this some kind of sick prank?"

"Sir, this might sound completely insane," Alex pleaded, "even I don't understand what's happening to me!"

Smith slammed his hand onto the table, the sharp echo cutting him off. "You trespassed on private property, threatened residents, and earlier this evening, you pulled a stunt at a diner because you couldn't pay your bill, rambling about swipe-pay and futuristic nonsense. Either this parallel-universe theater ends right now, or you're going to spend your foreseeable future locked in a maximum-security psychiatric ward or a prison cell. You're young. Don't throw your life away. Back off."

The sheer weight of the threat chilled Alex to the bone. With no rational proof or defense, he realized fighting back was useless. Defeated, he muttered an apology.

Ten minutes later, he was shown the door, released back onto the dark, unforgiving streets of Lawrence, Kansas.

Driven by instinct, Alex walked straight back to where his nightmare had begun the hospital entrance. Near the curb sat an abandoned yellow canvas tent, its flaps whipping in the wind. He ducked inside. The ground was littered with crumpled bills, old receipts, and discarded brochures marked with an unfamiliar, star shaped emblem.

He gathered the papers, slipping them into his coat pockets before heading out into the open street. He stopped pedestrians, flashing the star logo, but met only blank stares and dismissive shakes of the head.

Exhausted and parched, he approached a small street vendor to buy a bottle of water. As he laid a crumpled brochure on the cart to fish out his change, a young boy standing nearby eating a snack froze, pointing a sticky finger at the paper.

"Hey, that's the Bellstar Studios logo," the boy said.

Alex blinked, caught off guard. "The what?"

"Yeah, Bellstar Studios. The creators of the *OWI* series."

"I don't follow," Alex said, his brow furrowing. "What do they make?"

"Games," the boy replied, as if stating the most obvious fact in the world. "*Open World Immersion*. It's a massive video game franchise."

Panic and confusion warred in Alex's mind. He thanked the boy and began asking passersby for directions to the studio's headquarters. The answers hit him like a physical blow: the main offices were in New York City. Stranded in Kansas with empty pockets, no phone, and no money for transport, reality set in. Walking or hitchhiking to New York was impossible, and any attempt to beg for cash only drew mockery or threats from locals warning him to stay away.

Watching from across the street, Mary Richards observed the scene. Seeing him repeatedly rebuffed by strangers, a sudden pang of sympathy softened her defensive stance. She crossed the asphalt and called out to him.

Alex spun around, instantly bracing for a confrontation. "I'm sorry, ma'am! I swear I wasn't trying to bother you "

"Mary," she interrupted gently, holding up a hand. "Just Mary. What are you actually trying to do? What kind of trouble are you mixed up in?"

Desperate for an ally, Alex poured out the entire story once more, pulling the crumpled brochures from his coat and thrusting them toward her. "And this logo... I found it where I woke up. It has to mean something."

Mary looked down at the weathered paper, a look of profound pity crossing her face. "Alex, these are just vintage promo sheets. They updated their branding years ago." She pulled out her phone, opening her social media feed to display Bellstar Studios' modern corporate profile. "Look. They're a multi-billion-dollar enterprise. You can't just walk into their corporate offices."

"You don't understand " Alex started.

"Alex, you need professional help," she said softly, stepping back. "You need to contact the authorities."

"Stop!" Alex's voice cracked with raw desperation. "You can walk away right now, or you can help me. Those are my only two choices."

Mary stared at him for a long, quiet moment, weighing the risk. Finally, a sigh escaped her lips. "Come on. My house isn't far. You can get out of the cold."

Alex hesitated. "Are you sure? Do you live alone?"

"Yes, I do," she replied, offering a faint, hesitant smile. "Just me."

"Do you have a... partner? Family?"

The smile lingered, softened by a touch of amusement. "No. I'm single."

"I'm sorry," Alex quickly apologized, looking down at his shoes. "I didn't mean to pry. I just... I don't want to intrude."

"It's fine," Mary said, turning toward her street. "I know you don't have anywhere else to sleep tonight."

As they walked back toward the house, the silence between them felt less hostile.

"What do you do for a living, Mary?" Alex asked to break the quiet.

She stumbled slightly on the pavement before recovering. "Oh... I'm a journalist."

"What firm?"

"My own. I'm self employed."

Alex offered an appreciative nod. "That takes courage, living out here on your own."

They reached the house and stepped inside. Mary showed him to a modest guest room down the hall, offering a clean towel before retreating to her own quarters for the night. Left alone in the quiet dark, the weight of the impossible world pressing down on him, Alex finally let his exhaustion take over, collapsing onto the bed as sleep dragged him under

Chapter Three: The Weight of Proof

Sunlight filtered through the gaps in the bedroom curtains, casting sharp, dusty lines across the floor. Alex woke early, washed his face, and stepped outside to freshen his suit using water from an outdoor tap. He called out for Mary, but the house remained silent.

Walking into the living room, he spotted a handwritten sticky note left on the coffee table near the sofa: *"I'll be back soon. Please help yourself to the coffee and breakfast."*

Waiting on the table was a steaming cup of coffee and a slice of blueberry pie. Hungry and parched, he ate quickly. Afterward, he took a quick shower, hoping the hot water might snap him out of his surreal reality. He checked the guest room closet for spare clothes, but finding nothing, he reluctantly put his slightly damp suit back on.

To pass the time, he turned on the living room television. The channels felt profoundly wrong. Flipping through the guide, he found unfamiliar networks and sports broadcasts with strange team names. Stopping on a football match, he frowned at the screen, muttering to himself. In his memory, the top Spanish division was called La Liga, yet here the ticker referred to it entirely as Liga Espanyol. Name changes and subtle shifts echoed across every broadcast, feeding his mounting disorientation.

A knock at the front door broke his spiraling thoughts. Peering through the peephole, a wave of relief washed over him when he saw Mary standing on the porch.

She rushed inside, talking quickly before he could even speak. "I'm so sorry I had to run off this morning. I freelance, mostly gathering photographs and local news tips to sell to larger outlets." She offered a slightly embarrassed smile before regaining her composure. "Did you have your breakfast?"

"Yes, I did. Thank you," Alex replied.

There was a brief, awkward pause as both struggled to keep the conversation moving. Mary cleared her throat and handed him a shopping bag. "By the way, I picked up some new shirts and trousers for you."

Alex stared at the bag, genuinely touched by the gesture. "Thank you, Mary. Really."

"I also bought you a mobile phone and a prepaid SIM," she added, looking away slightly. "Since you don't have any identification documents of your own, I had to register it under mine."

Alex stood frozen. A rush of complex emotions stirred inside him gratitude, confusion, and a sudden, sharp ache as he remembered his missing wife. *What is happening to me? Am I trapped in some kind of dream?* He felt a flicker of warmth toward Mary, though he quickly forced himself to suppress it, keeping his loyalty to Sarah firmly anchored in his mind.

Mary crossed her arms, turning serious. "Before you dive headfirst into your own investigation, let me ask you something."

"What?"

"Are you genuinely convinced this is your house?"

Alex nodded, his expression heavy. "In my memory, yes. I lived here for the last five years. I'm sorry things turned out this way, Mary. I never wanted to intrude, but the interior layout has

completely changed." He slumped onto the sofa, the vulnerability breaking through his defenses. The future felt terrifyingly abstract and hostile.

Mary sat beside him, her voice softening. "Alex, none of the numbers or places you've mentioned exist here. This is Lawrence, Kansas. You know that, right?"

"I know where Lawrence is," Alex said, his voice cracking. "I just don't understand why the people and places are different. Should I go to the police? My wife is missing "

"No," Mary interrupted firmly. "If you go back to the police without proof, they won't listen. You need hard evidence to back up your claims."

Alex looked up, studying her face. "Then why are you helping me? Why give me a chance to speak instead of treating me like a criminal?"

Mary hesitated, her breath catching for a second as she looked away. "I felt a sympathy for you. You seem genuine."

"Then why did the cops treat me like an animal?" Alex asked, his pitch rising with emotion.

"Hold your horses," Mary cautioned, placing a hand on his arm. "Let's investigate together and find some answers."

An hour later, they drove to a local Starbucks to meet Caleb Kemp, a contact of Mary's in the reporting business. As they sat at an outdoor table, a sleek car pulled up to the curb. Caleb stepped out, walking over with a smirk plastered across his face.

"Sorry I'm late," Caleb said, his eyes darting toward Alex. "Is this the parallel-world guy?"

Alex stiffened, the disrespect stinging, while Mary shot Caleb a sharp, warning glare.

"I'm sorry, I didn't mean to offend you, sir," Caleb muttered unconvincingly. Turning back to Mary, he continued, "The company he mentioned Bellstar Studios is an elite tech and gaming developer. They've been around for decades, known for absolute perfectionism. They're the only company with zero security leaks and zero hacks. They're the best at what they do. Why are you so obsessed with them?"

"I found their promotional brochure right where I woke up," Alex said.

Caleb offered a mocking snort. "Oh, Jesus. Was that right next to the interdimensional portal?"

"Caleb, please be serious," Mary snapped.

"Fine, fine," Caleb relented, rolling his eyes. "Look, mister. That's your only lead? You wouldn't even get past the first security gate on their premises. They don't deal with outsiders or weirdos " Caleb caught Mary's furious glare and stumbled over his words. "I I didn't mean it like that. Look, I have some friends who cover gaming news up in New York. I'll ask around if they've heard anything unusual."

Caleb gestured for Mary to step away with him for a private conversation. Reluctantly, Alex excused them.

Standing by the edge of the parking lot, Caleb kept his voice low and urgent. "What is wrong with you? This guy needs help. Are you out of your mind?"

"He reminds me of Jacob," Mary said defensively.

"Stop it," Caleb snapped back. "Jacob is dead! And this guy is a total wacko."

"Alex isn't "

"Listen to me," Caleb interrupted. "If you keep playing along with this, you're going to end up in legal trouble, or worse, dragged down with him. You need to put him in an asylum."

Without waiting for a response, Caleb turned on his heel and walked back to his car, driving off without another word.

Alex watched Caleb leave, his shoulders slumping. He looked up at Mary as she walked back to the table. "He thinks I'm crazy, doesn't he?"

"Don't worry about him," Mary said softly, taking a seat. "Like I told you, people won't believe us until we find hard proof."

Without another word, they walked back to the car and drove in silence back to the quiet safety of Mary's house.

Chapter Four: The Fall of the Mask

The front door clicked shut behind them as they stepped into the quiet hallway of Mary's house. The weight of the evening hung heavily in the air.

Alex turned to face her, his expression shifting from the vulnerable stranger he had played for hours into something entirely unreadable. "Mary, I need to tell you something. I am not Alex Donovan. There is no Alex Donovan, and there never was a wife. What I am about to tell you will sound impossible."

Mary froze. Her eyes darted toward the kitchen counter, her instincts screaming that something was deeply wrong. Without breaking eye contact, she slowly backed toward a hallway drawer, her fingers sliding inside to feel for the cold steel of the handgun she kept hidden there.

"You must be so confused by all of this, I know," Alex continued, stepping closer.

Before he could finish, Mary whipped the drawer open, yanked the pistol out, and leveled it straight at his chest. Her hands shook violently. "Stay back! Don't move another inch!"

Alex let out a slow, heavy breath. He didn't flinch. "That won't do a thing to me. I am not human."

Panic overriding her judgment, Mary pulled the trigger. The gunshot cracked through the small house like thunder. The bullet struck Alex dead center, but instead of piercing flesh, it flattened against him like a tiny piece of paper, dropping harmlessly to the floor.

Mary stared in absolute horror, her legs giving out beneath her as she collapsed backward onto the floorboards.

Stepping forward calmly, Alex knelt down, keeping his voice low and steady. "You need to calm down, please."

She struggled to find her voice, gasping for air. "What... what are you? Who are you?"

"My name is Araziel," he said softly. "I am an angel of the Lord Jesus Christ. Your former partner, Jacob, crossed a line he never should have. He attempted to sell an artifact one of the few divine objects God placed upon the Earth."

Araziel paused, his eyes darkening with a sorrowful gravity. "I was supposed to intercept him and manage the situation, but I failed to act in time. Unlike you mortals, we do not get second chances. I fell from my Lord's grace. The only way I can return to my place in heaven is if I recover that artifact and put it back where it belongs. If I fail to do so before the appointed hour, this entire world will burn, along with the cast-out souls and those who rejected the teachings of Christ."

Mary's mind spun, the pieces crashing together with terrifying speed. "So... what did Jacob do?"

"He tried to sell it to devil worshippers just to mock the divine," Araziel replied.

"Is it the Eucharist?" Mary asked, her voice trembling.

"No, it is not the Eucharist. You wouldn't understand what it truly is. But I need every detail you know about Jacob and his contacts."

Terror finally curdled into pure rage. Mary scrambled backward, pointing a shaking finger at him. "Get out of my house! I don't want anything to do with you, you twisted freak! Get out! I thought I was helping a desperate man who lost his wife, and you're not even human! If you don't leave right now, I swear I'll call the cops!"

"I understand your anger, Mary," Araziel said calmly, remaining seated. "But your reward for helping me will be greater than you can imagine. Listen to me carefully: I cannot be seen, nor can my true name be spoken aloud in this realm. Doing so alerts other angelic and demonic beings. If they discover I am wandering down here, and that my only hope of saving the world relies on you, the very first thing they will do is erase you from existence."

Mary stopped, her breath hitching. "What are you trying to say?"

"I am not one of the wicked ones, Mary," Araziel explained, his expression earnest. "When I was punished, God kept my fall hidden from the high hosts of heaven and hell because a chance for redemption still remains if I find that artifact in time. But if the demons discover my purpose here, it will take them only a heartbeat to realize why I am walking among you. The good news is that Jacob only took the artifact from its sanctuary; he never managed to hand it over to them. I must retrieve it before they find it. Do you believe in God, Mary?"

"No," she spat out, tears welling in her eyes. "And I never intended to."

"May Christ have mercy on you, then," Araziel whispered.

"I don't know anything about this artifact!" Mary cried out, pressing her back against the wall. "I didn't know anything about Jacob's secret business!"

"Of course you didn't," Araziel said. "He was only ever a pawn."

"A pawn?"

"He met an entity named Orias, who was disguising himself as an angel of the Lord. Jacob summoned him. From what I know, Orias is a brutal adversary once those forces sink their claws into a mortal, escape is nearly impossible."

"Boyfriend," Mary corrected automatically through her tears, the painful correction slipping out. "He was my boyfriend."

"Forgive me. Yes. He was a librarian, correct?"

Mary nodded numbly.

"While sorting through the old, restricted archives in the library of St. Paul de Morale in New York," Araziel continued, "a piece of that divine archive went missing. Jacob was deceived by the adversary; a dark thought was planted in his mind to open and read it. That artifact is a book, containing the secrets of the upper dimensions and creation itself. It belonged in the Vatican Secret Archives. It went missing during its transit. We do not know the exact terms of the pact between Orias and Jacob, but the book was moved from its resting place to that library."

Araziel sighed, his gaze dropping to the floor. "Before Jacob, others tried to steal it. Everyone who tried before met their end killed by my hand, because I was the one assigned to guard it. And by killed, I do not mean mere physical death; I had to erase their existence entirely to keep the divine secrets hidden from this world. We engineered situations to trap them, waiting for them to take the bait. But the problem is that when I erased Jacob's memories and tracked his path, the book was no longer where it should have been. He had a human accomplice. And we are running out of time."

The blood rushed out of Mary's face. The horrifying reality crashed over her: the stranger sitting in front of her was the exact being responsible for her boyfriend's death.

A fresh wave of grief and fury broke through her shock. Screaming in anguish, Mary lunged to her feet, grabbing heavy decorative objects and books from the nearby shelf, hurling them straight at him with all her might.

Araziel didn't flinch as the items bounced harmlessly off his shoulders. "Everyone has their duty to perform. Your duty as a human was to live your life. Your partner tried to bargain with upper-dimensional powers, and he paid for his temporary earthly happiness with his life. He asked for worldly rewards, and believe me, he received them though I am certain that within a few short months, every single one of those gifts will curdle into a curse."

Standing amid the scattered debris, chest heaving and tears streaming down her face, Mary choked out, "What am I supposed to do now?"

Araziel stood up, dusting off his immaculate suit jacket. "You should go to your room and rest. We will talk more in the morning."

Chapter Five: The Shadow and the Seal

The next morning, Mary woke up with a start. Sitting quietly in the chair beside her bed was Araziel.

She gasped, pulling the blanket to her chest. "When did you get in here?"

"Just now," he replied smoothly, raising a hand in a placid gesture. "I didn't mean to frighten you. Take your time."

She demanded he wait in the living room while she finished her morning routine. He complied without argument, sitting patiently on the sofa until she emerged a short time later.

She crossed her arms, fixing him with a skeptical look. "If you're an angel like you claim, how come you ate the food yesterday?"

Araziel offered a faint, dry smirk. "Well, I actually didn't eat it. The food simply vanished the moment it passed my lips. Angels do not require sustenance, just as we do not sleep."

"So, getting back to what you were saying last night," Mary said, taking a seat opposite him. "You think Jacob had help moving the artifact?"

"Yes," Araziel said, his tone turning grave. "Whether he acted alongside someone else or consulted outside forces, his final days were chaotic. His choices brought him to a bitter end."

A flash of raw grief and anger flared in Mary's chest. "It was your duty to keep him from doing it! You said you were responsible for protecting those divine objects!"

"Hold your ground right there," Araziel countered, his voice dropping an octave, carrying a sudden, heavy resonance that made the air in the room feel thin. "Free will is granted to all mortals and angels alike. He chose to transgress against divine law. Trying to communicate with the dead or meddle with other dimensions is explicitly forbidden if you read the scriptures, you would know that. The Book of Deuteronomy forbids such practices. Furthermore, while my primary duty was to guard the artifact, I was constrained for reasons I cannot yet share."

Mary stared at him, tears stinging her eyes. "Where is God, then?"

Araziel blinked, slightly taken aback. "What do you mean? You mean my Lord Jesus? He is right where He has always been. He is present everywhere. He respects human free will and its consequences, even when those choices break His heart."

"Then why doesn't He come down physically and fix this?"

"He will," Araziel said quietly. "And that day is closer than any of you realize."

Mary wiped a tear from her cheek. "So what should I call you? You said your true name and presence can't be broadcasted."

"Call me Alex," he answered. "That is why I had to construct a false identity to blend in with you. I apologize for the deception."

Watching him closely, the sheer surreal absurdity of the situation began to settle into a strange, accepting calm within Mary. She hesitated, a bizarre curiosity cutting through her grief. "Do you... do you feel sexuality? Romance?"

Araziel let out a short, humorless laugh. "Not anymore. Angels possessed those capacities long ago, back when certain members of our host took mortal wives. The Nephilim were born from those unions, and the wickedness that followed forced a devastating reckoning. God revoked that sensation from us. The daughters of men are breathtaking and eloquent, and even angels fell victim to that distraction. God created humanity with endless potential, but your kind so often misuses it."

You always have your justifications, but excuses do not change reality. No one can ever win an argument against God. He upholds His laws and honors free will without bending them. You don't need to worry about me in that regard, Mary."

Mary flushed, turning her gaze away as a sudden wave of awkwardness filled the room. She cleared her throat, eager to change the subject. "So how do we track down that artifact?"

"We start by examining Jacob's inner circle," Araziel said. "His friends, family, and allies. Anyone close to him during his final weeks."

"Can we go back to the St. Paul de Morale library?"

"I already searched the premises thoroughly," Araziel answered. "There is nothing left there."

Over the next few hours, they set out to visit the homes of Jacob's relatives and associates. To avoid drawing unwanted attention or tying Jacob's tragic end to Mary, Araziel remained in the car, pretending to be her driver.

Later that afternoon, they stopped at an open air diner for a quick cup of coffee. As they sat discussing their next move, the screech of tires interrupted them. Three men in dark suits stepped out of a sleek sedan, marching directly toward their table. The leader, a sharp-faced man wearing an expensive jacket, pulled up a chair uninvited and sat down heavily.

"Hello, ma'am," the lead man said, flashing a cold, predatory smile. "Does the name Henry Reeds ring a bell?"

Mary's blood ran cold. She recognized him instantly as the powerful state governor whose massive corruption scandal she had recently exposed online. She stiffened, keeping her voice flat. "I don't know what you're talking about. Leave us alone."

"Cut the crap, Mary," the jacketed man snapped, slamming a hand on the table. "Delete that video you posted on YouTube right now. Upload a retraction stating it was false propaganda you manufactured for clout."

Frustration and fury surged through Mary. Before she could fire back, Araziel stood up, stepping smoothly between them. "Gentlemen, surely you can speak to a lady with a bit more respect."

The man looked up, sizing Araziel up with a sneer. "And who the hell are you?"

"My name is Alex Donovan," Araziel replied evenly.

The man scoffed, glancing sideways at Mary. "What is this, your new boyfriend?"

Mary seized the moment, her voice sharp. "Yes. He is. Now get away from us."

"Or what?" the man challenged.

Before Araziel could react, the man lunged forward and shoved him hard against the chest. Araziel hit the ground, stumbling over a chair.

"Alex!" Mary screamed.

The two heavies joined in, raining kicks and heavy punches down onto Araziel as he curled defensively on the pavement. Mary wept openly, screaming for them to stop, but the crowd of onlookers backed away in terror.

With a final warning to delete the video or face far worse consequences, the thugs turned, jumped back into their sedan, and sped away.

Sirens wailed in the distance as police and paramedics arrived minutes later. Bystanders rushed over to help, whispering among themselves in utter bewilderment. Only moments before, they had clearly seen blood pouring from Alex's nose and severe bruising across his face. Yet, as the paramedics knelt beside him, his skin was entirely clear, every scrape and bruise vanishing as if it had never existed.

"Are you alright, sir?" the paramedic asked, shining a light in his eyes. "That was a brutal beating, but you look completely untouched."

"It was just a minor scuffle," Araziel said calmly, standing up without a hint of pain. "I'm fine."

Shaking their heads at the impossible recovery, the authorities wrote it off as an adrenaline-fueled fluke.

Back inside the safety of Mary's house, she hovered anxiously around him. "Are you sure you're okay? They beat you mercilessly!"

"I am completely fine, Mary," Araziel assured her, pouring her a glass of water. "What about you?"

"I'm shaken," she admitted, sinking onto the sofa. "That man is Henry Reeds. The Governor of Kansas. He's a vicious, corrupt animal who cares about nothing except power and money. I'm so sorry you got dragged into that because of me."

"You don't need to apologize," Araziel said softly.

"Why didn't you fight back?" Mary asked, her eyes searching his face. "You survived a gunshot wound like it was nothing. You could have destroyed them."

Araziel's expression darkened. "If I wanted to, I could snap my fingers and reduce them to dust before they could even draw a breath. But the energetic consequences of wielding my power outside of divine mandate are severe. Everything in the cosmos is energetically linked. Even if you cannot perceive it, your soul feels the shockwave. Because we are angelic beings, drawing that kind of raw power leaves a beacon. If my brothers or worse, the adversaries realize I am walking this earth using my gifts openly, they will descend upon us. We cannot afford that kind of attention."

Mary swallowed hard, finally understanding the terrifying fragility of their mission. She reached into her bag and pulled out a notepad filled with jotted addresses, phone numbers, and notes from their interviews with Jacob's family. "Here. This is everything I gathered today."

Araziel took the notes, glancing over them. "Thank you. You must be exhausted. Eat something, get some rest, and we will resume tomorrow."

She nodded tiredly, retreating down the hall to her room.

Once the door clicked shut, Araziel walked into his guest room and locked the latch behind him. He closed his eyes, sliding into deep mental communion, projecting his awareness upward to scan the spiritual horizon for any cascading divine signatures or demonic disturbances.

So far, the radar remained silent. He exhaled slowly, settling into a deep, silent meditation as the dark Kansas night settled over the house.

Chapter Six: The Magic Man and the Midnight Meeting

The morning sun cast a pale light across the diner table as Alex looked across at Mary. His expression held a faint, gentle smile, but it was anchored by a profound, unyielding seriousness.

Mary stirred her coffee. "What?"

"I just wanted to thank you," Alex said quietly. "For everything. What you are doing right now is remarkable, especially given that you don't believe in God."

"I still don't," Mary replied, meeting his gaze with a stubborn edge. "I'm just curious. I saw you, and I still haven't seen Him."

Alex gave a slow, understanding nod. "Fair enough. Now, please, let me see those addresses you collected."

Mary handed over her notepad. He flipped through the pages, scanning the names David Ruiz, Benny Clay, Father Georgy until one specific line caught his eye. He paused, his finger tapping the paper. "Who is Neil Blackman?"

"He's a friend of Jacob's, and a business partner," Mary explained, leaning back. "They run a magic club together."

Alex furrowed his brow. "A magic club? What is that?"

Mary blinked, a sudden spark of playful teasing breaking through her exhaustion. "You don't know what magic is?"

Alex straightened up, his tone entirely serious. "I know what magic is. I mean, what is a *magic club*?"

Her face flushed pink. "It's... it's a massive illusion empire business. They perform grand stage shows across the globe."

"Did you meet Mr. Blackman yesterday?"

"No," she admitted. "I only spoke to his manager. He claimed Jacob hadn't been in contact with them for a long time."

Alex's forehead furrowed deeper with suspicion. "We need to pay him a visit. But I'm not going with you. You need to go alone and meet him face-to-face." He leaned in slightly. "When you see him, bring up something random like the classic illusion secret of cutting a woman in two pieces and joining her back together."

Mary stared at him, genuinely offended. "Are you out of your mind? That's absurd! I'm not close enough to him to bring up stage tricks out of nowhere, and even if I did, why would he ever answer me?"

"Exactly," Alex responded smoothly. "If he stumbles, fumbles, or gets defensive, tell me he's our guy. But if he laughs it off, brushes it aside, or acts genuinely annoyed like any normal person would, he's likely clean. Either way, he probably won't tell you the real secret, but we need to watch his reactions. His gestures will speak for themselves."

"And if I do that," Mary pressed, crossing her arms, "what does a stage magician have to do with the divine artifact?"

"I cannot tell you much more right now," Alex said firmly. "We are searching in the dark, and we desperately need a breakthrough. Just do it."

Later that afternoon, Mary walked down a quiet street toward the local grocery store. As she navigated the sidewalk, her phone buzzed in her hand. It was Caleb Kemp.

"Mary," Caleb said through the speaker. "It's Kemp. I looked into that studio you asked about nothing unusual, and that brochure you found was ancient. By the way, is that guy Alex Donovan still with you?"

Mary froze for a fraction of a second, deciding not to give away details. "Yeah. Why?"

"Well," Caleb continued, sounding uneasy, "I ran his name through a few state databases IDs running from age twenty to twenty-eight. None of them match his face, and the guy has zero social security number or passport history. Honestly, Mary? I think he might be an illegal immigrant, or a ghost. There's literally no data on him anywhere."

"Right. Yeah, I'll look into it," Mary muttered.

"Hey, are you alright?" Caleb asked, his tone shifting to genuine concern. "Please be careful around him."

A sudden, impulsive thought struck Mary. She stopped walking near a brick wall. "Caleb? Can I ask you something?"

"Sure, what is it?"

"Do you... do you believe in angels?"

There was a brief pause on the line, followed by a sharp, sarcastic laugh. "Yeah. Candice Swanepoel, Adriana Lima, Barbara Palvin? Victoria's Secret angels? I know those ones."

Frustration flared in Mary's chest. "Never mind. See you later."

"Wait, wait, I'm sorry!" Caleb laughed. "What do you mean? Like the celestial, supernatural winged creatures? Of course not! Why are you asking me that?"

A wave of immediate regret washed over Mary. "Never mind. Just a stupid question. See you later." She hung up before he could answer, dropping her phone into her bag. Caleb, utterly bewildered, went back to his desk.

Inside the bustling grocery store, Mary stared at her phone while pushing a cart. She hovered her thumb over Alex's contact, wanting to call him, then pulled back. *No, don't bother him with this right now.* She went back and forth, staring at the screen.

Suddenly, an elderly woman firmly tapped her shoulder from behind. Mary jumped, letting out a sharp gasp.

"Excuse me, ma'am, move your cart aside, you're blocking the vegetables," the woman snapped impatiently.

Flustered, Mary apologized, quickly grabbed her essentials, and hurried back to the house.

When she unlocked the front door and stepped inside, the house was dead silent. Alex wasn't there.

Panic and a bitter, hollow ache twisted in her chest. She immediately dialed his number, but it rang straight to a dead silence he didn't pick up. The sheer intensity of his absence hit her harder than she expected, leaving her pacing the living room floor.

A sharp knock at the door made her jump.

She rushed over, peering anxiously through the peephole. It was Caleb. Not having the emotional energy to deal with his questions, she stood completely frozen, deciding to pretend she wasn't home and plan an excuse for tomorrow *I was asleep*. After a few heavy moments, Caleb sighed on the porch and walked away.

Hours bled into the night. Midnight had long passed when the front door clicked open.

Mary woke up on the sofa, blinking away sleep as Alex stepped inside. She blinked in confusion he was completely soaked, droplets clinging to his clothes and hair, even though there hadn't been a single cloud or drop of rain outside all night.

"Where have you been?" she asked, her voice raspy from sleep. "And why are you completely wet?"

Alex closed the door softly, his face unreadable. "I was busy with my own matters."

"You're drenched," Mary insisted, standing up. "What happened?"

Alex exhaled slowly, looking at her with a heavy, otherworldly intensity. "Every year, at this exact time, all celestial beings both the fallen and the loyal host are summoned into a mandatory spiritual conclave with God. We hold a collective accounting regarding the state of humanity. I had to project my consciousness into my true spiritual form to attend and ensure my cover remained airtight."

Mary stared at him, a chill running down her spine. "You... you went to heaven?"

"Not heaven. The convergence," he corrected quietly. "And it worked. No angel or demon suspected a thing. To them, I am still just a cast-out fallen soul trapped deep beneath the earth. And that is exactly how it needs to stay."

She stood frozen, a mix of sheer terror, awe, and disbelief gripping her throat.

Suddenly, Alex's expression darkened, snapping back to the immediate crisis. "Did you go? To Mr. Blackman's office or his house like I told you?"

Mary shrank back slightly. "I... I'm sorry, I didn't."

Alex's face hardened with pure frustration. "Mary, do you understand what just happened? During the Great Meeting, every celestial consciousness was locked into that conclave. If Mr. Blackman is connected to the artifact theft, and someone senses prying eyes right now without that book secured... he might reach out to Orias or the others. If they realize an investigation is active, it's going to blow our cover wide open."

He stepped closer, his voice dropping into a stern, non-negotiable command. "You *must* go tomorrow. No excuses."

Cowering slightly under the sudden, crushing weight of his anger, Mary swallowed hard and whispered, "I'm sorry. I'll do it."

Without another word, she turned and retreated down the hall to her bedroom, the heavy door clicking shut behind her. Down the corridor, Alex locked his own door, closed his eyes, and sank immediately back into deep, silent meditation, scanning the spiritual ether for any ripples of incoming danger.

Chapter 7 The Melting Point

The next morning, Mary bypassed Neil Blackman's downtown offices entirely and headed straight for his private residence.

As she approached the towering iron gates, a hidden sensor clicked. An electronic voice crackled to life, instructing her to look directly into the security lens. She complied. A moment later, the camera whirled, processing her face before Blackman's voice came through the intercom, smooth and effortless, welcoming her inside. The heavy gates swung open.

Stepping onto the grounds felt like entering another world. The mansion was sprawling, its architecture sleek and imposing, surrounded by surfaces so polished they mirrored the morning sun. A guard met her at the heavy double doors, escorting her directly into a vast, luxurious living room.

Not long after, Neil appeared, wearing an easy, casual smile.

"I'm sorry about Jacob," Neil said, taking a seat opposite her. "He was so good to me. One of my partners in these adventures. Though... to be honest, he wasn't really into the magic itself. More into the old books."

Mary accepted his condolences with a quiet nod, keeping her guard up. "How is everything else going?"

Neil leaned forward, his eyes glinting. "I should ask you that. How are you holding up? Everything fine?"

A faint, artificial smile touched Mary's lips. They exchanged polite, empty pleasantries before she decided to steer the conversation where Alex had directed.

"I heard about your magic act," Mary said, watching him closely. "The illusion... splitting a woman in two and putting her back together..."

She searched his face for any slip, any hidden detail of the supernatural machinery Alex had warned her about. But Neil looked entirely ordinary. Unbothered. Completely wrapped in his own ego.

"...How could you possibly do that?" she finished, letting the question hang.

Neil gave an eloquent, practiced smile. "That's why they call it magic, isn't it? Beautiful. Don't we all love a good mystery?"

Mary offered another plastic smile, realizing her purpose here was already slipping through her fingers. "Thank you for your time, Neil. I should go."

Neil halted for a fraction of a second, his expression sharpening. "Why are you leaving so soon? You haven't even told me why you came."

Panic fluttered in her chest. She was trapped, forced to invent a reason on the spot. Desperate for an excuse, she pretended to be struggling financially. True to form, Blackman immediately seized the opportunity for self-promotion, offering to pay her to film a promotional video for his upcoming shows. Then, narrowing his eyes, he added a jab that hit too close to home: *"Why aren't you doing your own videos anymore? It's been a while, hasn't it?"*

"Just no relevant news these days," Mary muttered.

She left the mansion with a sharp exhale of relief, her nerves frayed. But the moment she reached her apartment building later that afternoon, a familiar voice called out from the shadows.

"Mary... Mary... one thing. How did it go?"

Alex stepped out, demanding answers immediately. Inside the apartment, she recounted every detail of the meeting. Hearing Blackman's name only fueled Alex's restless paranoia. Mary's face flushed with deep, unmistakable frustration the exhaustion of being dragged into a 21st-century proxy war involving ancient, invisible entities.

Alex saw it, and for a second, his demeanor softened. "I'm sorry, Mary. If I've been mean to you... I know you're doing more than you should."

Yet, the reprieve lasted only a heartbeat. Before she could breathe, he pressed her again, demanding she investigate the other people tied to Jacob and Blackman's inner circle.

Mary felt cornered. Before she could push back, Alex vanished with a curt, *"I'll be back."*

Standing alone in the quiet apartment, the bitter realization settled in: Alex was using her. He only offered scraps of sympathy when her anger flared, treating her well-being as an afterthought. Restless, drained, and desperate for normalcy, she decided to confide in Dr. Chloe Monroe her therapist and close friend. But a knot of fear tightened in her stomach. Would reaching out to Chloe violate Alex's strict rule never to speak of him?

She sat heavily on the sofa, pulling up Chloe's contact. Her phone buzzed with notifications messages from worried subscribers and friends asking why her channel had gone dark, why she had vanished from the local news scene. The weight of her old life called out to her, pulling at her spirit until she felt entirely hollowed out.

Impulsively, she dialed Chloe and booked an emergency appointment.

She hurried down the sidewalk toward the clinic, her mind racing, when a voice stopped her dead in her tracks.

"Hey! What is wrong with you?"

Caleb jogged up from behind, breathless and agitated. "I've been calling you for two days! You didn't pick up the phone what the hell happened?"

"Nothing," Mary deflected, her voice tight. "It's just... you know."

"So where are you headed?" Caleb demanded, narrowing his eyes.

"I'm just going to talk to Chloe."

Caleb crossed his arms, visibly suspicious. "What happened? You look terrified. And where is Mr. Parallel World?"

"He... went out," Mary murmured.

A heavy, awkward silence stretched between them. Caleb stared at her, reading every defensive micro-expression. "Are you guys seeing each other?"

"No, we're not dating," she snapped.

"Then this is completely messed up," Caleb fired back, his voice rising. "If you're not dating, why is he still living in your apartment?"

"That is none of your business!" Mary yelled, the accumulated stress of the past week finally boiling over.

Caleb stepped back, stung. "Okay... okay." Without another word, he turned and walked away.

The outburst left Mary entirely depleted. The mood for therapy, for talking, for pretending everything was fine it was all gone. Defeated, she turned around and walked back home.

Later that evening, past six o'clock, a knock sounded at her door. Knowing Mary's habits, Chloe had grown too worried to stay away and had driven straight to the apartment.

Mary opened the door, a wave of relief washing over her, though she quickly tried to mask her frayed nerves. "Chloe..."

"Why didn't you show up?" Chloe asked, stepping inside uninvited, her eyes sharp and analytical.

"I'm sorry, I must have lost track of time. It wasn't anything serious, just it's been a long time since we caught up, you know "

"Stop playing around, girl," Chloe said firmly, cutting through the excuses. "What is the matter with you? What actually happened?"

Knock. Knock.

Before Mary could answer, another sharp knock interrupted them. Mary opened the front door to find Alex standing on the threshold.

Without missing a beat, Alex stepped inside, pulled Mary into a tight embrace, and kissed her cheek. "Hey, darling. I am so sorry the traffic was absolute murder. By the way... who is this?"

Sensing an outsider, Alex instantly shifted into the performance of a doting, attentive boyfriend. Mary numbly introduced them. Chloe's sharp eyes darted between the two of them, taking in Alex's rehearsed backstory and noticing the glaring disconnect in Mary's body language.

With a polite, guarded smile, Chloe gathered her things. "Well, it was lovely meeting you, Alex. See you later, Mary."

As she walked out to her car, Chloe pulled out a small notebook and made a sharp, deliberate note regarding Mary and her sudden "boyfriend."

The front door clicked shut. The mask instantly dropped.

"What were you thinking?" Alex hissed, turning on Mary.

"What?" she whispered, backing up.

"You were about to melt in front of her. Mary, what is happening? Am I rushing you?"

Mary stood completely silent, the pressure building behind her ribs until she couldn't take it anymore.

"I'm sorry, Alex," she whispered, her voice shaking. "I'm done. I can't do this anymore. This isn't my world it's too much."

Alex froze, desperation hardening into something cold and terrifying. "Mary. You gave me your word. You promised you would help me find that book."

"I'm sorry," she repeated, tears pricking her eyes.

His voice dropped into a chilling, subterranean register. *"Sorry doesn't cut the deal. You aren't making a promise to a bunch of fragile humans. You are making a promise to me Araziel. A hand touched creation of the Lord Himself."*

The air in the room pressure dropped instantly. Alex's eyes flared with a blinding, unearthly light. As his voice spiked to a deafening, high decibel resonance, the shockwave shattered the living room window into a million glittering pieces.

Mary screamed, stumbling back against the wall.

Instantly, Alex reined himself in, his expression flattening as he fought down the terrifying surge of his true nature.

"I'm sorry," he breathed, his voice trembling as he stared at his hands. "I... I'm losing myself." He looked up at her, raw terror bleeding through his celestial armor. "If I don't find that book before the time runs out, I won't just fail. I will lose what's left of my grace entirely. I will become just like the rest of them. Pure evil."

Mary stared at him, paralyzed. The words felt like spear points piercing her heart. Living here wasn't just stressful she was sharing a roof with a ticking cosmic time bomb.

Heavy footsteps echoed outside in the hallway. Neighbors, alarmed by the shattered glass, began pounding on the door.

Panicked, Mary pointed toward the hallway. "Go get into my room. Now."

She threw open the door for the neighbors, waving away their frantic questions with a breathless lie. "I'm so sorry! I was just... testing out my new home theater speakers. The bass was too high. I'm so sorry about the mess."

When she finally managed to close the door and return to the living room, she found Alex sitting on the floor, soaked in cold sweat, his head in his hands.

She asked what happened, but he remained entirely silent.

Instead, he closed his eyes, his lips moving in rapid, silent supplication. *I'm controlling the urge. I'm praying to the Father for the grace to hold on.*

Without looking up at her, his voice heavy with exhaustion, he whispered, "Go to sleep, Mary."

And there, in the dark wreckage of the room, the fallen angel resumed his vigil, praying and meditating against the dark tide rising within him.

Chapter 8: The Falling Sky

The next morning, Mary woke with a heavy dread settling in her chest. She walked straight to Alex's room and pushed the door open.

It was entirely empty. Every object, paper, and piece of furniture was scattered across the floor in a chaotic, violent mess. Panic gripped her throat. Without a second thought, she pulled out her phone and called Caleb.

He arrived at her apartment minutes later. Standing amid the wreckage, Mary finally broke down and spilled everything she had kept hidden from him the secrets, the terror, the impossible weight of what she had been living through. She expected Caleb to look horrified. Instead, a dry, disbelieving laugh escaped him.

"Mary, look at yourself," Caleb said, shaking his head. "You look terrible. You need help."

"What do you mean, *I need help*?" she snapped, grabbing his arm. "Where do you think Araziel went?"

Caleb crossed his arms, standing firm. "I don't care where he is. He's completely a wacko."

Frustrated to the point of tears, she pointed toward the shattered window from the night before, desperate for him to see the physical proof of Alex's fury. But Caleb just stared at her, completely unconvinced.

Suddenly, a cold spike of fear hit her. She remembered Chloe visiting the night before, and how she hadn't been able to reach her since. Without another word, Mary bolted out the door, Caleb trailing closely behind. They hurried down to the garage, climbed into her car, and sped toward Chloe's apartment while Mary frantically dialed her number over and over. Ring after ring no answer.

When they pulled up to Chloe's building, the front door was ajar. They stepped inside to find a scene of absolute horror: the apartment was trashed, glass and debris scattered across the floor, and dark smears of blood tracked down the hallway.

Mary's heart stopped. Following the bloody trail, she pointed with a shaking hand toward the bathroom. Caleb stepped forward, pushing aside a rack of clothes hanging near the threshold.

The sight made him stagger back, his face draining of all color. "Oh, my God... Jesus, Mary, Joseph..." he stammered, panicking as reality crashed down on him.

Mary rushed past him and looked inside. Chloe's body hung limply, her hands and feet bound with strips of cloth. A brutal, gaping wound pierced straight through her chest a hole that looked as though a spear had driven entirely through her heart.

A piercing scream ripped from Mary's throat as she collapsed, sobbing uncontrollably. Caleb tried to pull her back, to console her, but Mary was already shattered into a million pieces.

"It was him," Mary wept, her voice trembling with hysteria. "It was Alex. He thought I told her about him he killed her!"

Caleb shook his head, his own voice rising in desperate denial. "Mary, you are insane! There is no fucking angel, and there is no fucking demon. You are out of your goddamn mind!" Refusing to let her spiral further, he forced her back and dialed the emergency services.

Within minutes, police cruisers and forensic teams swarmed the building, sealing off the horrific crime scene. Detectives questioned Caleb and Mary while she sat in the back of a squad car, tears still streaming down her face.

As they drove away later that afternoon, Caleb broke the silence, his voice laced with heavy pity. "The cops aren't going to believe a word of what you said, Mary. The angels, the supernatural story... you're suffering from severe delusions. I'm so sorry."

"Then where is he?" Mary shot back, her voice hollow. "That wacko is out there somewhere, and he could kill anyone."

"Mary, I know Jacob's death messed you up, but this is worse," Caleb muttered, gripping the steering wheel. "You have his number, right? We can track him."

They tried to trace his phone, but it had been left behind, discarded in Mary's apartment. The tension snapped. Caleb began firing blame at both Alex and Mary, letting slip a bitter truth of his own that he was an undocumented immigrant who had slipped into the United States and spent his life running scams just to survive. By the time he dropped her off, the gulf between them was unbridgeable.

Mary walked up to her house alone. As she forced herself to start cleaning up the devastating mess of her living room, her hand brushed against something soft on the floorboards.

She picked it up. It was a feather.

It was about the size of her palm, but unlike anything she had ever touched or seen in her life. Its color shifted like liquid silk, yet no hue on earth matched its exact shimmer. When her fingers brushed against it, the texture was impossibly, comfortingly soft.

Feeling a strange, magnetic pull of curiosity, she slid the feather into a plastic protective folder, grabbed her car keys, and drove down the street to the local textile mill, a short ten minute drive away.

She bypassed the front desk, asking to speak directly with the manager. After a brief wait, an employee ushered her into a private office.

"Good to see you, Mary," the manager, Simon Wayne, greeted warmly with a smile. "I used to watch your current affairs videos all the time. Nothing new coming out lately what happened?"

Brushing past the question with a vague excuse, Mary opened the plastic folder and laid the feather on his desk.

Simon leaned in, expecting a routine textile sample. But the moment his eyes hit the object, his smile vanished. He stared at it, completely baffled, before asking her to wait a moment. He stepped out of the room, returning a minute later with his chief designer carrying a massive, leather-bound historical textile archive a tome over twelve hundred pages long.

Flipping through the heavily worn, middle pages around the six-hundred-page mark, Simon's finger stopped on a specific entry:

Sea Silk (historically known as Byssus or il bisso).

Simon compared the page to the object in front of him. "It's similar to the sea silk model," he murmured, his hands shaking slightly as he looked up at her. "But this... this is infinitely older. More ancient than anything recorded here. No human being has ever woven or even laid eyes on a feather like this. It's an absolute masterpiece. Mary... if you can bring me more material like this, I will write you a blank check."

Panic spiked through her chest. Snatching the folder back, Mary stood up abruptly. "I'm sorry, Mr. Wayne. I have to go."

Wayne tried to urge her to stay, but she rushed out the door. A moment later, she hesitated, turned back, and asked him to print out the reference details he had just shown her. Though Wayne feared she was taking her business to a rival mill, she assured him it was for personal reasons. He watched her leave with a heavy, disappointed sigh.

When Mary finally pulled up to her house, she found Detective Smith waiting by her porch.

"Good afternoon, Mary," he said smoothly.

"Good afternoon, Officer," she stammered, her nerves fraying.

"Detective," he corrected her gently.

Detective Smith began pressing her for details regarding the wild statement she had given to the dispatch unit earlier that day. Standing her ground, Mary repeated the entire truth about Alex and Araziel.

Detective Smith didn't laugh, but his eyes narrowed with recognition. He already knew who Alex was; local police had flagged him previously for trespassing on Mary's property. When Mary desperately tried to explain *why* she had allowed him in, Smith held up a hand.

"I'm sorry, ma'am, but the law doesn't recognize celestial beings or fugitives from heaven," Smith said calmly. "We have to log this case under the name he gave us: **Alex Donovan.**"

She swallowed hard and nodded.

"What's that in your hand?" Smith asked, noticing the folder.

"It's a feather," Mary said quietly. "I found it when I cleaned up his room."

Detective Smith offered a skeptical, almost mocking smile. Without missing a beat, Mary handed him the printout she had gotten from the textile mill. He read through Simon Wayne's notes, his expression shifting from amusement to curious intrigue. He borrowed both the printout and the feather to examine them.

Inviting him inside, Mary watched as the detective inspected Alex's former room. Because Mary had already scrubbed the space clean, nothing unusual remained save for the lingering phantom weight of what had been there.

"I'll call you, Mary," Detective Smith said, pocketing the printout and the feather before heading back to his car.

Standing alone in her quiet, shattered home, Mary realized with bone-deep despair how entirely her life had unraveled into an inescapable nightmare.

Chapter 9: Move on

The following day, Mary received the call from the detective. She drove down to the station, her chest tight with lingering dread. Stepping through the heavy double doors, she found the interior dark and utterly deserted, every object and file scattered haphazardly across the floor. A cold shiver ran down her spine.

Before she could retreat, the heavy door slammed shut behind her, plunging the room into absolute blackness.

A deafening, high pitched screech suddenly drilled through her ears a violent, piercing shockwave that felt identical to the terrifying frequency Araziel had unleashed in her living room. Mary screamed, throwing her hands over her ears.

Pop! Pop! Pop!

Bright colors exploded in the dark. Party poppers showered her in metallic confetti as the overhead lights flickered back on.

Officer Smith stepped forward, a wide grin on his face, clapping his hands as he began to sing, *"Happy birthday, Mrs. Richards."*

Mary stood frozen, her brain completely short circuiting.

Out from the shadows stepped Caleb, followed closely by Chloe looking entirely unharmed, with not a single trace of the brutal, spear-like wound that had ended her life. And right behind them stood Alex.

A wave of dizzying vertigo washed over Mary. Was she hallucinating? Was this the aftershock of trauma, or had none of it ever been real?

Alex stepped into the light, his expression softer, entirely stripped of the terrifying celestial menace. "Sorry, ma'am," he said smoothly. "It was all quotation. None of it is real. It was entirely scripted."

Mary stared at him, her voice a hollow whisper. "You what?"

"My name is Matt Callahan," he continued, holding up his hands in a placating gesture. "I'm just a relima director. It's a real-life interactive cinema. We design and plot the narrative, but you—you were the main character off-script. The story developed organically according to your real actions, though everything was pre-written toward a climax." He gestured vaguely around the room. "Our company is Matter Dynamics. We try our best to direct you toward the endpoint, though you tended to go way out of scope."

Mary's mind reeled back to the terrifying night in her apartment. "What about when I shot you? The bullet didn't go through you!"

Matt offered an apologetic, disarming smile. "We switched the bullets, ma'am. I'm sorry for the scare."

Caleb stepped up next, laughing off the tension. "Sorry, girl! The whole Bellstar Studios setup and those reports on the mayor? All me. With the mayor's permission, of course."

Chloe walked over, stepping into the circle with a warm, apologetic look. "I'm sorry, dear. I was paid to play my part. That wound you saw? Special effects courtesy of Matter Dynamics. I'm so sorry we had to put you through that."

Detective Smith chimed in, scratching his head. "And that feather? Matt planted it for you. I didn't even know it was a prop until I arrested Mr. Callahan outside your house. He explained the whole thing during processing well, after the fact, before he left."

Amidst the shock, a sudden realization hit Mary. "Wait... who ordered this? Who paid for the quotation?"

Detective Smith chuckled, turning toward the back office doors. "Come on in, sir, please."

Mary's face drained of all color. Her jaw went slack.

Walking through the door with an easy, familiar grin was **Jacob Holt** her ex-fiancé, the man she had mourned, the man who had supposedly died in a tragic accident.

For a second, the room spun. Mary's knees buckled, and she fell hard against the floorboards. Jacob rushed forward, catching her by the arms and helping her back to her feet.

"Jacob... where have you been this whole time?" she breathed, tears stinging her eyes.

"It was all part of the script," Jacob said lightly, brushing dust off her jacket. "To make my absence feel as impactful to you as possible."

"What?" she whispered, the sheer absurdity crashing over her.

"Remember last year when you said your birthday gifts never felt like they had any real magic or vibe to them?" Jacob explained, smiling. "Well, I met Mr. Dignam he's a friend of a friend and he pitched this exact idea. I thought, *why not give a shot to a relima experience for her birthday?* Don't panic, Mary. It was all for you."

As the initial shock began to recede, a profound, overwhelming wave of relief washed over her. Jacob pulled her into a warm embrace, thanking the cast and crew for pulling off the most elaborate performance of their lives. The group exchanged laughs and congratulatory slaps on the back before filtering out into the afternoon sun.

As Matt Callahan walked toward the exit, Mary caught his eye. A strange, heavy pang of longing tugged at her chest a sudden, confusing sense of missing the man who had shared her home, even if he was just an actor playing a part. But she purposefully suppressed the thought, shoving the emotion down. Matt, seasoned by years in the relima industry, was well trained in handling the complex emotional fallout of his subjects. Though a genuine part of him had grown attached to her during the simulation, he locked those feelings away, deciding it was time to let go and move on.

Later that evening, back at the Matter Dynamics headquarters, Matt handed over his comprehensive case report on Mary Richards.

His employer, Roland Dignam, looked over the files with an expression of deep satisfaction. Dignam also took custody of the raw video footage, captured by hidden cameras strategically placed throughout Mary's home and neighborhood long before the action ever unfolded. Though Matt had carried out the role of the lead actor on the ground, Dignam had been the master architect and true director behind the scenes, assigning aliases and tracking the narrative beats against the

master plan. Payouts were meticulously calculated based on performance metrics and emotional yield.

"I'm sorry, Dignam," Matt sighed, rubbing the back of his neck. "I've gotta take a break. That one... that one was too much for even me."

Dignam didn't look up from his desk. "Fair enough. Three weeks alright with you?"

Matt offered a tired, cynical smile. "That's too bad. Whatever, boss."

With that, Matt left the office, drove straight to the airport, and booked a one way flight back to New York.

Hours later, he unlocked the door to his tiny, modest apartment in the Park Slope neighborhood, located beneath a building known as Jefferson's Roof. A familiar, hollow ache settled into his bones the heavy, undeniable weight of Post-Acting Depression (PAD) that always followed the end of a long-term simulation.

He dropped his bag, took a long, steaming shower to wash off the ghost of Azael, and threw together a quick sandwich in the quiet kitchen.

As he sat down at the small table, his phone buzzed on the counter. A notification flashed across the screen:

100 dollars was credited to your account.

Matt stared at the glowing numbers. A bitter, self-deprecating laugh escaped him. He had just put his heart, soul, and sanity through a psychological gauntlet for a hundred bucks. Yet, he knew full well he couldn't pull off anything better in traditional theater or conventional jobs.

Sighing, he unlocked his phone, scrolled to his photo gallery, and hovered his thumb over an image of Mary Richards. With a sharp motion, he hit delete, erasing the last tangible link to the illusion.

It was past six o'clock when he arrived; now the clock read nine.

Matt clicked on the television, letting the drone of a random football match wash over him as exhaustion finally dragged him under. He slumped back against the sofa and drifted into a heavy sleep, a handful of potato chips slipping from his lap and scattering onto the floor as the TV flickered on in the empty room, casting a restless, glowing light into the dark.

Acknowledgement

This is the first novel artwork of mine. The novel had to pivot in many directions for reasons people cannot fully comprehend, so a scripted narrative suits the balance of the readers' minds in the current situation. People are not yet capable of conceiving the impact of the parallel truths of this world, and as a matter of fact, I believe the turn this story took is really important.

I hope Matter Dynamics and its team will return for new perspectives good or bad, you decide.

Thanks to whoever made it to this acknowledgments page.

Continue reading!

- Joshwa Jose